

Pakistan as the Taliban may get even more confident following international efforts to woo them. At last month's London conference to discuss the future of Afghanistan, most countries including the five permanent members of the UN Security Council (the US, the UK, Russia, China, and France) overwhelmingly supported the policy of talking to the Taliban. This stems from the assessment that the US and its NATO allies perceive Afghanistan to be a protracted battle and now want to look for quick-fix solutions that will help them exit the country early.

For Delhi, it is bad news, as was the snub which kept them on the margins of the London conference. National Security Adviser Shiv Shankar Menon's visit to Kabul scheduled for March 5 is an indication that, pushed to the wall, India will be desperately seeking to formulate a new strategy, diplomatically and in terms of security.

India is left with few options. It has no say in the international community's "good Taliban" strategy and will continue to engage closely with the Hamid Karzai Government and provincial satraps. In addition, it can use back-channels to try and keep communications open with those Taliban elements who shun violence as they could eventually find space in the political mainstream. India is looking to bolster its security personnel as also its current training programme for Afghan officers.

The ITBP earlier had a presence of around 350 personnel when India's largest effort—the 218-km Zaranj-Delaram highway was being built. The ITBP currently has a force of 150 troopers guarding the Indian embassy in Kabul and the consulates at Mazar-i-

Who India is up against

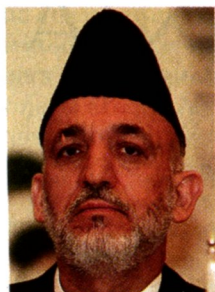
The ISI is using Pak-based insurgents to target Indian interests in Afghanistan



Sharif, Jalalabad, Herat and Kandahar. A review of the security is to be carried out following Menon's visit. Deploying Indian troops in Afghanistan to safeguard Indian interests has been entirely ruled out. However, a growing consensus has been building within Indian military think tanks for training at least two divisions of the Afghan National Army (ANA). A net assessment presented last month for the Centre for Joint Warfare Studies (CENJOWS), the think tank for the tri-services' HQ Integrated Defence Staff,

calls for the capacity building of the ANA. "India could offer to pay for and equip and train up to two Afghan divisions—an artillery and armoured brigade each of the ANA—over and above the sanctioned strength of 1,34,000," says Major General (Retd.) G.D. Bakshi, who headed the study. CENJOWS has also suggested that India could provide T-55 tanks and field guns or howitzers.

But while providing military equipment may help, India must expose the role of Pakistan's intelligence agency ISI behind the earlier attack on the Indian mission in Kabul, and its alleged links with the attackers of the recent blast more forcefully. Whatever steps India finally takes, its Afghanistan strategy needs a major rethink. After February 26, the rules of the great game have drastically changed.



“This was a terrorist attack against Indian citizens who are working to help rebuild Afghanistan. We will provide security to Indians and will do everything possible to nab the perpetrators of this attack.”

HAMID KARZAI, *President, Afghanistan*